year old Manipuri woman, alleged to be a separatist, who was brutally tortured and killed within hours of her arrest. This incident led to widespread protests across the state, including an iconic nude protest by twelve 'imas' [mothers] with banners reading 'Indian army rape us' and 'Indian army take our flesh'.) The committee observed that the AFSPA had become 'a symbol of oppression, an object of hate and an instrument of discrimination and highhandedness'.[28] It recommended repealing the AFSPA and placing some of its provisions into a different law, the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act of 1967.

The Second Administrative Reforms Commission of the central government, chaired by Veerappa Moily, also recommended the repeal of AFSPA in 2007.[29] In 2013, the Justice Verma Committee – chaired by the same judge who was on the bench that decided the Naga People's Movement case – stressed the need to review the continuance of the AFSPA 'as soon as possible'.[30] The same year, the Justice Hegde Commission observed that the AFSPA had 'little or no effect' on insurgency in Manipur.[31] There was wisdom in this observation – something must have been amiss when 'disturbed area' notifications remained in place in the same location for decades.

From 2015 onwards, governments finally began lifting 'disturbed area' notifications from parts of the Northeast. By early 2019, disturbed area notifications were withdrawn entirely from Meghalaya, and from parts of Arunachal Pradesh and Tripura. The AFSPA itself, however, remains on the statute book despite its legitimacy having been chipped away for years by scholars, public officials and human rights organizations.[32] Unlike civil society organizations, the court had the authority to go beyond merely recommending, advising and warning. It missed the opportunity to do so in 1997. That error would prove especially costly.